



Code

MFEM Workshop 2026

Particle-in-cell in MFEM

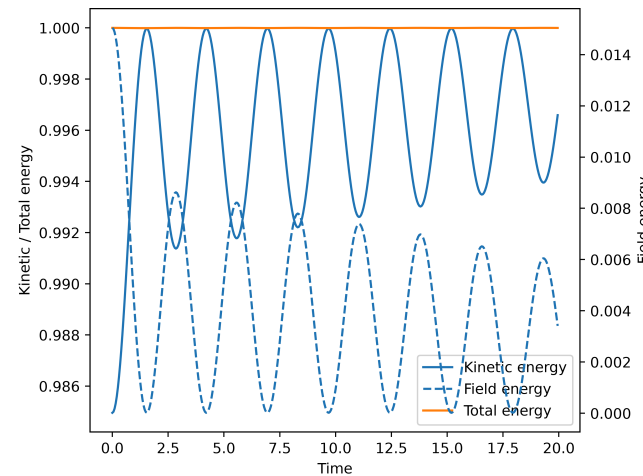
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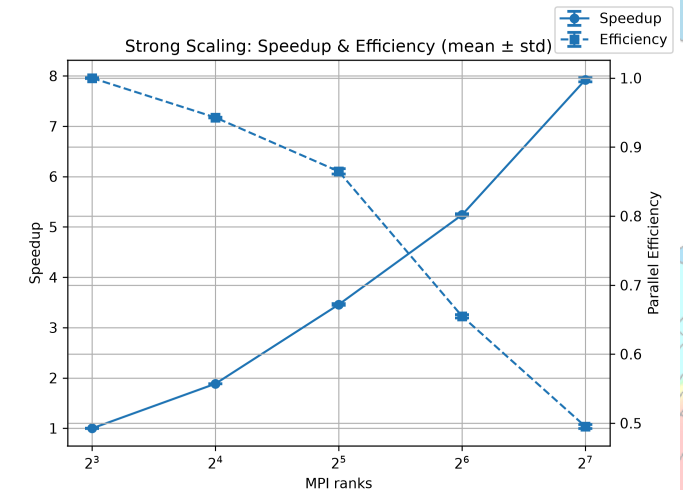
Electrostatic PIC in
MFEM with support for
unstructured meshes

Biharmonic-heat shape
function suppressing
grid heating

Symplectic preserving
with compatible FEM



Parallel scalable
with MPI





Code

One PIC time step in MFEM

particles $\xrightarrow{\text{deposit}}$ field $\xrightarrow{\text{push}}$ particles

1. Deposit charge.

For $\varphi \in H^1(\Omega)$, assemble $e \sum_p \varphi(\mathbf{x}_p)$.

2. Solve Poisson.

OrthoSolver removes the periodic nullspace.

$$\epsilon_0 \langle \nabla \varphi, \nabla \phi \rangle = e \sum_p \varphi(\mathbf{x}_p) - en_0 \int_{\Omega} \varphi.$$

3. Compute field.

$$\langle \mathbf{v}, \mathbf{E} + \nabla \phi \rangle = 0 \text{ in } H(\text{curl}).$$

4. Gather field.

Interpolate $\mathbf{E}$ at each $\mathbf{x}_p$.

5. Leapfrog push.

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{p}_p^{t+\frac{1}{2}\Delta t} &= \mathbf{p}_p^{t-\frac{1}{2}\Delta t} + e\mathbf{E}^t(\mathbf{x}_p^t)\Delta t, \\ \mathbf{x}_p^{t+1} &= \mathbf{x}_p^t + \mathbf{p}_p^{t+\frac{1}{2}\Delta t} \Delta t / m_p. \end{aligned}$$

6. Redistribute.

Exchange particles that cross MPI ranks.

Low-pass shape function

The shape function is the biharmonic heat kernel at time τ :

$$s_{\mathbf{x}}(\mathbf{x}) = E(\mathbf{x}, \tau), \quad \hat{E}(\mathbf{k}, \tau) = e^{-\kappa(2\pi/L)^4 \|\mathbf{k}\|^4 \tau}.$$

Applying $s_{\mathbf{x}}$ is equivalent to convolving the Dirac charge and the potential with that kernel:

$$\rho = s_{\mathbf{x}} * \rho_{\delta}, \quad \epsilon_0 \Delta \phi = \rho, \quad \phi_s = s_{\mathbf{x}} * \phi, \quad \mathbf{E}_p = -\nabla \phi_s(\mathbf{x}_p).$$

